County of San Diego, Health and Human Services Agency (HHSA)
CalWORKs Program Guide/CalFresh Program Guide Special Notice

Social Security Administration - Cost of Living Adjustment	Number	Page
	CalWORKs 23-07 CalFresh 23-05	1 of 2

Effective Date:
January 1, 2024

Background:
Social Security Administration (SSA) recipients will receive a 3.2 percent Cost-of-Living Adjustment (COLA) effective December 2023, and payable January 1, 2024. In addition, starting January 2024 the Medicare Part B premium will increase to $174.70 per month.

Policy:
A COLA mass update will run on December 2, 2023, automatically adjusting SSA benefit amounts and Medicare Part B premiums for open SSA and Medicare expense records in CalSAWS. On December 9, 2023, a batch Eligibility Determination Benefit Calculation (EDBC) run will occur and effective January 2024 CalWORKs/CalFresh benefits will reflect the SSA benefit and Medicare premium increases.

The automatic adjustment will **not** occur on cases where there was a discrepancy. Cases not included in the COLA run will require staff to manually update the information in CalSAWS to reflect in the January 2024 benefits.

When updating the SSA benefit amount the calculation is to be completed as follows:

Step	Action
1	Use the previous SSA Title II benefit amount
2	Multiply the amount by 1.032
3	Round down to the next lower dollar (remove the cents)
4	Final amount will be the new anticipated SSA benefit amount

Treatment of SSA COLA for Ongoing Semi-Annual Reporting (SAR) Customers
The SSA COLA is considered a mid-period county-initiated action. As a result, a decrease in CalWORKs/CalFresh benefits may occur effective January 1, 2024, with timely and adequate notice.

Income Reporting Threshold (IRT) Requirements
CalWORKs customers are required to report if the increase in SSA benefits combined with earned income, results in exceeding their IRT. If income exceeding the IRT is reported an evaluation is required to determine if the customer is still eligible to benefits. If CalWORKs discontinues due to exceeding the IRT, the CalFresh households (HH) is eligible to Transitional CalFresh (TCF).

CalFresh HH must report if the increase in SSA benefits combined with all other income the HH receives results in exceeding their IRT. If income exceeding the IRT is reported an evaluation is required to determine if the HH is still eligible to benefits.

Treatment of SSA COLA for CalWORKs Annual Reporting/Child Only (AR/CO) Cases

The only cases where this action will not be considered mid-period are those AR/CO cases with a December 2023 redetermination. For those cases, include the updated SSA benefit amount in budgeting for the upcoming AR/CO period.

Timely and Adequate Notice

As with any adverse action, timely and adequate notice is required to decrease benefits. If unable to change the January 2024 CalWORKs grant/CalFresh allotment, take the appropriate action to decrease benefits the first of the following month after timely adequate notice can be provided. Recalculate January 2024 benefits using the increased SSA benefits and Medicare Part B premium amounts; and if the calculation results in a decrease, an overpayment/overissuance will need to be established as appropriate.

Procedure:

Case list reports requiring action will be issued to staff when available.

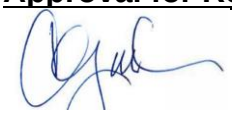
References:

ACIN No. I-64-23

Sunset Date:

This policy will be reviewed for continuance by December 31, 2024.

Approval for Release:



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